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ECHO

Where Past and Present becomes one

ECHO is an interactive book installation found around UQ in places where students pause, relax and spend time together. It brings the past and present together through stories of the university, its places and the people who have shaped it, while giving students a space to leave stories of their own.

In a shared digital garden, students' contributions grow into trees on a living map of UQ, helping them discover others, find shared experiences and feel more at home on campus. **Every story adds to a history that continues to grow with each generation.**



Problem Space

UQ has a rich history, but many of the stories behind its places and people go unnoticed in everyday campus life.

Our research suggests that discovering these stories can help students feel more connected to a place, yet busy schedules, lengthy resources and language barriers can make this difficult.

ECHO aims to bring history into students' everyday spaces, helping especially international and new students discover shared experiences, connect with others and feel more at home at UQ.

Interest in UQ History

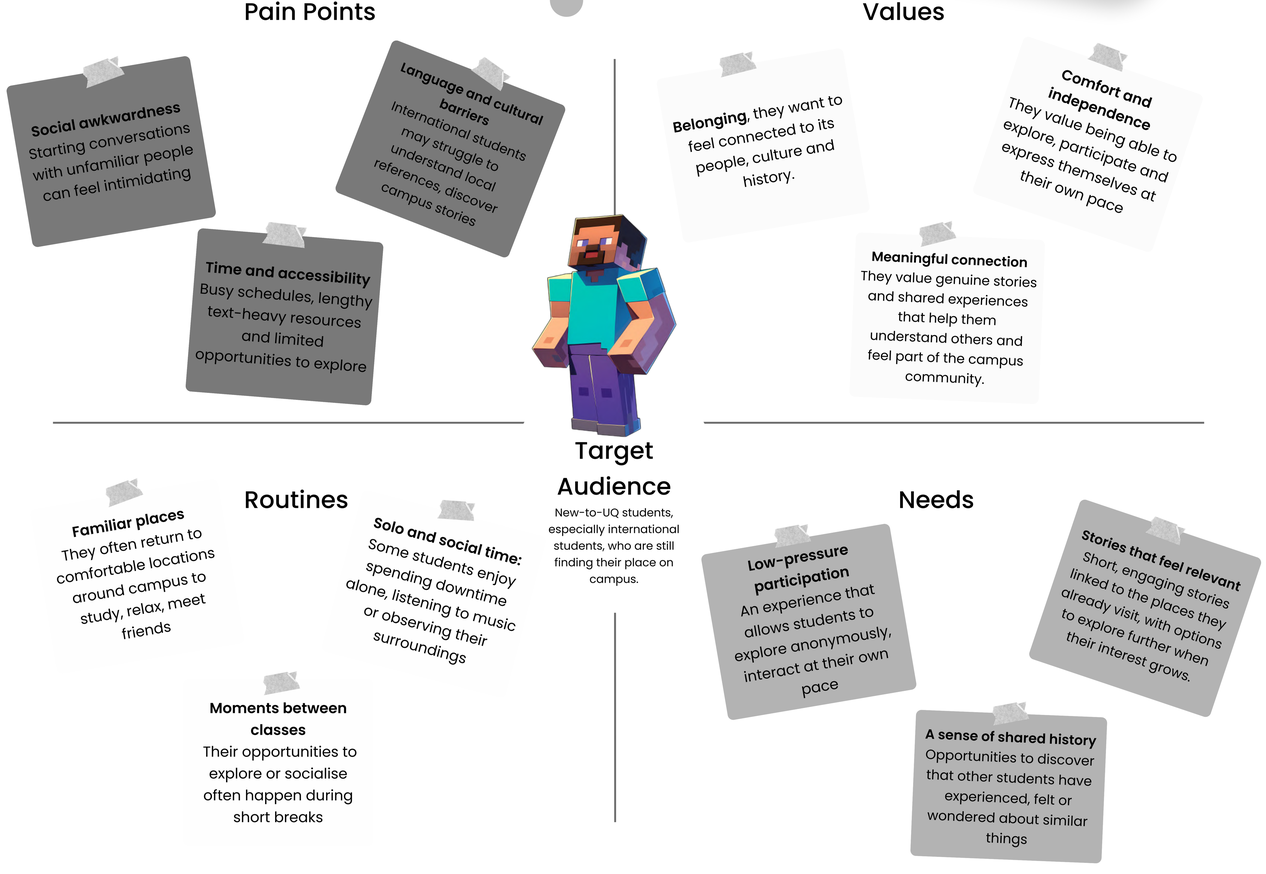
67% *Of participants*

There was interest in learning about UQ's history, culture or architecture. Their interests varied, from political history to the stories behind campus buildings.

Usual UQ Hangout space

75% *Of participants*

They have regular hangout spots around UQ, such as UQ Lakes and the Great Court. Where they have spent time relaxing, socializing, eating etc.



Insights and Opportunities

History is hidden in plain sight

Put stories directly where curiosity happens, so students can discover UQ's history without needing to plan a museum visit or complete a lengthy module.

> *"Sometimes I do look up and think about the history, but I'm usually too busy."*
> *— P4, initial interview*

Knowing a place can help it feel like home

Use stories to help students understand the place they're studying in and recognise the generations of people who have shaped it.

> *"Understanding that story basically makes you feel more involved in the place. It gives you a sense of home and comfort in it."*
> *— P2, first-semester international student*

Small moments can become meaningful interactions

Students often have only a short break and may not have the time or mental energy for lengthy content or reflective activities.

> *"I'm in between classes. I don't have a lot of thought power… leaving a picture or like a little voice note would be cool."*
> *— P3, Wizard-of-Oz testing*

Social connection shouldn't feel like a performance

For students who are shy, introverted or new to campus, interacting with an installation in full view of others can feel uncomfortable.

> *"I feel like I'd be a little bit embarrassed to sit at C… I'm sitting in front of everyone… so it's a little scary."*
> *— P7, User-Testing*

Students need different ways to experience stories

A single content format can exclude students with different preferences, listening needs or language backgrounds.

> *"It's purely because of my listening comprehension that I need subtitles to engage with a video."*
> *— P1, User-Testing session 1*

Everyday experiences are part of UQ's history too

Give students a way to document overlooked places, personal memories and everyday moments that future students might otherwise never discover.

> *"There's like a garden over there that has a bunch of… native berries and plants, which is really cool. It kind of gets passed by."*
> *— P1, Wizard-of-Oz testing*

Students have places they belong in UQ

Build on places students already visit instead of asking them to travel somewhere unfamiliar or attend a scheduled activity

> *"Great court is a good hangout spot. Get some food, chill in the grass, and that's the whole lot."*
> *— P5, user-testing interviews*

Stories should continue after someone leaves

A student's experience can disappear after a moment, with no easy way for someone else to discover it, respond or add their own perspective later.

> *"I like the aspect of leaving something to the next person."*
> *— P6, User-Testing Session*

Solutions and Features

PAIN POINT	ECHO FEATURE	HOW IT HELPS
01 Social interaction can feel awkward	**Anonymous ID + UQ Social Garden**	Explore and respond without a real-name profile; connect at your own pace, with live chat available when people are online.
02 Campus history can feel disconnected	**Location-specific campus map**	Each Echo opens stories for its own landmark and encourages visits to other Echo locations across UQ.
03 Contributions can be forgotten	**Personal trees, saved threads + alerts**	Each contribution grows a flower on the user's tree; saved threads and activity alerts make it easier to return
04 Language and media needs differ	**Multilingual, multimodal stories**	Offer text, audio and video, with subtitles and language options to make stories easier for more students to access.

PAIN POINT	ECHO FEATURE	HOW IT HELPS
05 UQ history goes unnoticed	**Discover UQ curated story threads**	Organises stories about UQ's places, people and history into themes students can explore through text, audio and video.
06 Students are only consumers of history	**Add to a thread or create one**	Students can add comments, photos, audio or video, turning existing stories into an ongoing shared conversation.
07 Limited Time and Attention	**Reel Mode short-form browsing**	Swipe through content from a topic or thread for a quick entry point, with deeper exploration available when wanted.
08 The installation might not look interactive	**Approach-activated book installation**	When a student approaches the book, it opens up and reveals the interface and allows exploration.

Ethics

- **Privacy:** Anonymous IDs, no real names or unnecessary personal data.
- **Consent:** Participation is voluntary; users choose what to view and contribute.
- **Moderation:** Review stories, comments and chats to prevent harmful content.
- **Indigenous rights:** Respect First Nations peoples' ownership, cultural protocols, consent, privacy and the authenticity of their stories.
- **Access and safety:** Multilingual support, subtitles, comfortable interaction and a clear exit option.

Future

- **A living campus archive:** Preserve UQ's history alongside the memories and experiences of each new generation.
- **Belonging beyond classrooms:** Help new students understand the university, discover shared experiences and feel part of its community.
- **History shaped by everyone:** Work with students, staff, archives and First Nations communities to preserve diverse stories respectfully for the future.

